JanGyan — Learn Without Limits

Category 4: Health & Emergency Awareness

Module 7 - Nutrition & Healthy Living

Module Overview

What we eat, drink, and how we move each day quietly shapes our long-term health more than almost anything else. This handbook is Module 7 of JanGyan's Health & Emergency Awareness category, and it gives every citizen a practical, science-based understanding of nutrition and healthy living, rooted in India's own official dietary guidance.

By the end of this handbook, you will understand what a balanced diet really looks like, how to read a food label, why safe drinking water and hydration matter, how to build a sustainable exercise habit, and how small daily routines add up to lasting health. This module is designed as a complete, self-sufficient guide.

Learning Objectives

After completing this module, you will be able to:

- Describe what a balanced diet looks like using India's own "My Plate" model.
- Identify the essential nutrients your body needs and why each one matters.
- Read a packaged food label confidently and spot misleading claims.
- Explain why safe drinking water matters and how India ensures it.
- Build a realistic, sustainable exercise routine.
- Understand BMI as one general screening tool, not a complete measure of health.
- Recognise the risks of excess junk food without falling into diet extremes.
- Build a simple, healthy daily routine that fits real Indian life.

Why This Topic Matters

Important

According to ICMR-NIN's Dietary Guidelines for Indians (2024), an estimated 56.4% of India's total disease burden is linked to unhealthy diets — and healthy eating combined with regular physical activity can prevent up to 80% of type 2 diabetes cases.

Nutrition isn't about strict rules or extreme diets — it's about consistent, informed, everyday choices. A citizen who understands portion balance, reads a food label correctly, and builds movement into daily life is far better protected against the lifestyle diseases covered elsewhere in JanGyan's Health & Emergency Awareness category.

This handbook translates India's own official nutrition science into simple, usable daily habits.

Introduction

Good nutrition means giving your body the right mix of food, water, and physical activity it needs to function well, grow, repair itself, and resist illness — without needing to be complicated or expensive.

Definition

A **Balanced Diet** is one that provides adequate amounts of all essential nutrients — carbohydrates, proteins, fats, vitamins, minerals, and fibre — in the right proportions for a person's age, activity level, and health needs.

India's national nutrition authority, ICMR-NIN, updates its Dietary Guidelines for Indians periodically to reflect the country's changing food environment — including, in 2024, sharper warnings about ultra-processed foods and clearer guidance on reading labels.

Fundamental Concepts

1. What Is a Balanced Diet? — "My Plate for the Day"

ICMR-NIN's "My Plate for the Day" model is a simple, visual way to balance meals without counting every calorie:

Portion of the Plate	What to Include
About half	Vegetables, fruits, and green leafy vegetables
About a quarter	Cereals and millets (rice, wheat, jowar, bajra, ragi)
About a quarter	Pulses, eggs, fish, or lean meat for protein
Small portion	Milk/curd and healthy fats (nuts, seeds, a little oil or ghee)

Indian Context

The 2024 Dietary Guidelines for Indians recommend sourcing nutrients from at least 8 different food groups across the day, rather than relying heavily on just one or two.

2. Essential Nutrients

Nutrient	Why It Matters	Common Sources
Carbohydrates	Main energy source for the body and brain	Rice, wheat, millets, potatoes
Protein	Builds and repairs muscles and tissue	Pulses, eggs, milk, fish, meat, soy
Fats	Supports hormone function and vitamin absorption	Oils, ghee, nuts, seeds
Vitamins & Minerals	Support immunity, bones, and countless body functions	Fruits, vegetables, dairy, nuts
Fibre	Supports digestion and steady blood sugar	Whole grains, vegetables, fruits, legumes
Water	Essential for nearly every bodily process	Drinking water, fluids, water-rich foods

Complete Detailed Explanation

This section covers each remaining topic with practical, everyday guidance.

3. Reading Food Labels

Under the Food Safety and Standards (Labelling and Display) Regulations, 2020, every packaged food sold in India

must carry specific mandatory information.

1. Check the **serving size** — nutrition information is often listed per serving, not per package.
2. Check how many servings are in the whole pack — eating the whole packet often means multiplying the listed values.
3. Look at energy, total fat, sugar, and salt per serving on the front or back of the pack.
4. Read the ingredients list — ingredients are listed in descending order by quantity.
5. Be cautious of claims like "healthy" or "natural" — verify against the actual nutrition panel.

> **Recent Development**
> In 2026, the Supreme Court of India directed the FSSAI to implement simple, easy-to-read front-of-pack nutrition labels — a major step toward helping consumers spot high fat, sugar, or salt content at a glance.

4. Safe Drinking Water

Water quality in India is benchmarked against the **BIS 10500** standard, which sets safe limits for at least 13 basic parameters.

- Use a proper filter or purifier if your tap or well water quality is uncertain.
- Boil water when in doubt, especially while travelling or during flooding.
- Store drinking water in clean, covered containers.

> **Indian Context**
> The Jal Jeevan Mission, launched in 2019 by the Ministry of Jal Shakti, has raised rural tap water connections from about 17% to over 80% of households, bringing safe piped water within reach of millions of families.

5. Exercise & Fitness

- Aim for at least 150 minutes of moderate physical activity a week — brisk walking counts.
- Include some strength-building activity (like bodyweight exercises) at least twice a week.
- Start small and build gradually rather than attempting intense workouts immediately.
- Choose activities you genuinely enjoy, so the habit lasts.

> **Indian Context**
> The Fit India Movement, launched by the Government of India in 2019, encourages citizens of all ages to build regular physical activity into daily life through community events, school fitness programmes, and simple at-home routines.

6. BMI Basics

Body Mass Index (BMI) is a simple screening ratio of weight to height, used as one general indicator of body weight category — not a complete measure of health or fitness.

BMI Category (WHO Asia-Pacific)	Range
Underweight	Below 18.5
Normal range	18.5 – 22.9
Overweight	23 – 24.9

Obese	25 and above

> **Remember**
> BMI doesn't account for muscle mass, age, or body composition. It's a useful starting conversation, not a final verdict — waist circumference and overall lifestyle matter too.

7. Healthy Eating Habits

- Eat meals at roughly consistent times each day.
- Include a variety of colours and food groups across the week.
- Eat slowly and pay attention to fullness cues rather than finishing out of habit.
- Cook at home more often, where you control ingredients and portions.

8. Junk Food Awareness

Ultra-processed and "junk" foods are typically high in refined sugar, salt, and unhealthy fats, and low in fibre and micronutrients.

- Occasional consumption is not harmful — the concern is frequent, excessive intake replacing balanced meals.
- Check labels for hidden sugar and sodium, which are often higher than expected.
- Keep healthier snacks (fruit, nuts, roasted chana) easily accessible at home to reduce reliance on packaged snacks.

9. Hydration

Water needs vary by body size, climate, and activity level. As a simple general guide for most adults:

Group	General Guidance
Adults (moderate climate)	Roughly 2.5–3 litres (about 8–10 glasses) daily
Hot weather or physical activity	More than the general guidance — thirst and urine colour are useful indicators
Pregnant women	Slightly higher intake, per ICMR-NIN guidance

10. Healthy Daily Routine

A sustainable healthy routine is built from a few consistent habits, not a single dramatic change:

Time of Day	Healthy Habit
Morning	A balanced breakfast and a few minutes of movement or stretching
Daytime	Regular meals, water breaks, and short movement breaks if deskbound
Evening	A lighter dinner, some physical activity, and reduced screen time before bed
Night	Consistent sleep timing of 7–9 hours

Important Terminologies

Term

	Simple Meaning
Balanced Diet	A diet providing all essential nutrients in the right proportions.
Macronutrients	Nutrients needed in large amounts — carbohydrates, protein, and fat.
Micronutrients	Nutrients needed in small amounts — vitamins and minerals.
Ultra-Processed Food	Food that is industrially manufactured with additives, often high in sugar, salt, or fat.
BMI	Body Mass Index, a screening ratio of weight to height.
FSSAI	Food Safety and Standards Authority of India, which regulates food safety and labelling.
Hidden Hunger	Micronutrient deficiency that exists even when calorie intake seems adequate.

Step-by-Step Understanding

Building a Healthier Routine, Step by Step

1. **Assess:** Take an honest look at your current meals, water intake, and activity level.
2. **Adjust the plate:** Gradually shift meals toward the "My Plate" proportions.
3. **Read before you buy:** Start checking labels on packaged foods you already purchase regularly.
4. **Add movement:** Introduce short, consistent activity rather than occasional intense workouts.
5. **Track loosely:** Notice patterns in energy, digestion, and sleep rather than obsessing over numbers.
6. **Adjust gradually:** Build one habit at a time instead of overhauling everything at once.

Real-Life Indian Examples

Example 1

A family in Indore switched from refined flour rotis to a mix of millets after learning about the "My Plate" model at a community health camp — they noticed better digestion and steadier energy within a few weeks.

Example 2

A young professional in Hyderabad started reading food labels out of curiosity and realised his "healthy" breakfast cereal contained more sugar per serving than he expected — a small discovery that changed his morning routine.

Example 3

A village in rural Odisha, newly connected under the Jal Jeevan Mission, saw a noticeable drop in water-borne stomach illnesses after households switched from a shared, unprotected well to piped, tested tap water.

Example 4

An office team in Pune started a shared 15-minute walking break every afternoon under the Fit India spirit — a small routine that stuck long after the initial campaign ended.

Practical Scenarios

Scenario	What You Should Do
A snack packet says "no added sugar" but tastes very sweet	Check the ingredients list for other sweeteners and the nutrition panel for total sugar content.
You're unsure if your tap water is safe to drink	Check if it's connected under Jal Jeevan Mission/BIS-tested supply, or use a proper filter/boiling as a precaution.
You want to start exercising but have no time for the gym	Start with a brisk 20–30 minute walk most days — consistency matters more than intensity.
Your BMI falls in the "overweight" range but you feel fit and healthy	Use BMI as one data point among several — discuss overall health with a doctor rather than reacting to the number alone.
You're craving something quick between meals	Keep simple options like fruit, roasted chana, or nuts on hand instead of only packaged snacks.

Government Rules & Guidelines

Programme / Body	Role
ICMR-National Institute of Nutrition (NIN)	Publishes India's official Dietary Guidelines and nutrient requirement standards.
Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI)	Regulates food safety, labelling, and the Eat Right India movement.
Jal Jeevan Mission	Provides safe piped drinking water to rural households nationwide.
Fit India Movement	Promotes regular physical activity and fitness across all age groups.
Poshan Abhiyaan (National Nutrition Mission)	Targets malnutrition among children, adolescent girls, and pregnant and lactating women.

Laws & Policies

Food Safety and Standards (Labelling and Display) Regulations, 2020

This regulation makes it mandatory for packaged food manufacturers to declare energy, fat, sugar, and salt content, the 8 major allergens, and manufacturer details clearly on the label — giving Indian consumers a legal right to accurate food information.

In 2026, the Supreme Court directed FSSAI to move ahead with simplified front-of-pack nutrition labelling, a significant step toward making healthy choices easier to identify at a glance, especially for consumers with lower literacy levels.

Important Statistics

Statistic	Insight
56.4% of India's total disease burden is linked to unhealthy diets (ICMR-NIN, 2024)	Diet is one of the single largest, most modifiable health factors in the country.
Healthy diet and physical activity can prevent up to 80% of type 2 diabetes cases	Shows the direct, measurable power of everyday lifestyle choices.
Rural tap water coverage rose from 17% (2019) to over 80% (2025) under Jal Jeevan Mission	One of India's most significant recent public health infrastructure achievements.
The 2024 Dietary Guidelines recommend at least 8 food groups for balance	Reflects updated science on dietary diversity, doubled from the earlier 4-group model.

Suggested Visual: A labelled "My Plate for the Day" diagram showing proportional food groups.

Best Practices

- Build meals around the "My Plate" proportions most days of the week.
- Read food labels before buying packaged snacks regularly.
- Stay consistently hydrated throughout the day, not just when thirsty.
- Move your body most days, even in short bursts.
- Cook at home more often, using whole, minimally processed ingredients.
- Treat BMI, weight, and how you feel as complementary indicators, not competing ones.

Common Mistakes

- Judging a food as "healthy" based on packaging claims alone, without checking the label.
- Skipping meals to "save calories," which often backfires later in the day.
- Drinking water only when already very thirsty.
- Starting with extreme workouts and quitting from burnout or injury.
- Treating a single BMI number as the full picture of one's health.

Myths vs Facts

Myth	Fact
"Skipping meals is an effective way to lose weight."	It often leads to overeating later and can disrupt metabolism over time.
"Fat-free or sugar-free always means healthy."	Such products can still be high in other unhealthy ingredients — always check the full label.
"Drinking more water than usual is always harmless."	Needs vary by person; extreme excess can occasionally cause its own problems — moderate, steady intake is best.

"You need a gym membership to get fit."	Brisk walking, home workouts, and daily movement are genuinely effective.
"BMI alone tells you if you're healthy."	It's one useful screening tool among several — not a complete health verdict.

Do's and Don'ts

Do	Don't
Check serving size before judging a food label's numbers	Don't assume front-of-pack claims tell the whole story
Drink water consistently through the day	Don't wait until you're very thirsty to hydrate
Build exercise into your existing routine	Don't rely on occasional, extreme workouts alone
Treat BMI as one indicator among several	Don't judge your health by a single number in isolation
Keep healthier snacks accessible at home	Don't keep only packaged, ultra-processed snacks within easy reach

Safety Tips

- Use filtered, boiled, or BIS-tested water, especially while travelling or during flood season.
- Introduce new exercise routines gradually to avoid injury.
- Check expiry dates and storage instructions on packaged foods.
- Consult a doctor before major dietary changes if you have an existing health condition.

Practical Checklist

Daily Nutrition & Activity Checklist

☐ Meals today roughly followed the "My Plate" balance
☐ Drank enough water through the day
☐ Checked the label on at least one new packaged food this week
☐ Got at least 20–30 minutes of physical activity today
☐ Chose a home-cooked or minimally processed meal today
☐ Maintained a consistent sleep and meal schedule

Quick Revision Notes

Revision

- "My Plate for the Day": half vegetables/fruits, a quarter grains, a quarter protein, plus dairy/healthy fats.
- Check serving size first when reading any food label.
- BIS 10500 is India's safe drinking water standard.
- Aim for 150 minutes of moderate activity weekly; walking counts.
- BMI is one screening tool, not a complete health verdict.

- Hydrate consistently — roughly 2.5–3 litres daily for most adults.

Key Takeaways

Key Takeaway

1. Balanced nutrition is about consistent proportion and variety, not restriction.
2. Reading food labels is a simple, powerful consumer skill.
3. Safe drinking water and regular movement are foundational, often-overlooked health basics.
4. BMI and other screening tools are useful starting points, not final judgments.
5. Small, sustainable daily habits outperform dramatic, short-lived changes.

Glossary

Balanced Diet — A diet providing all essential nutrients in the right proportions.

Macronutrients — Carbohydrates, protein, and fat — nutrients needed in large amounts.

Micronutrients — Vitamins and minerals — nutrients needed in small amounts.

BMI — Body Mass Index, a screening ratio of weight to height.

Ultra-Processed Food — Industrially manufactured food, often high in sugar, salt, or fat.

FSSAI — Food Safety and Standards Authority of India.

Hidden Hunger — Micronutrient deficiency despite seemingly adequate calorie intake.

Frequently Asked Questions

1. What is "My Plate for the Day"?

ICMR-NIN's visual model for balanced meals: roughly half vegetables/fruits, a quarter grains, a quarter protein, plus dairy and healthy fats.

2. How many food groups should a balanced diet include?

The 2024 Dietary Guidelines for Indians recommend at least 8 food groups across the day.

3. What should I check first on a food label?

The serving size — nutrition values are often listed per serving, not per whole package.

4. What is BIS 10500?

India's official drinking water quality standard, covering at least 13 basic safety parameters.

5. How much water should I drink daily?

Roughly 2.5–3 litres (8–10 glasses) for most adults, adjusted for climate and activity level.

6. How much exercise is recommended weekly?

At least 150 minutes of moderate activity, such as brisk walking.

7. What is BMI used for?

A simple screening indicator of weight category — one data point among several, not a full health verdict.

8. Is occasional junk food harmful?

Occasional consumption is generally fine; the concern is frequent, excessive intake replacing balanced meals.

9. What is the Jal Jeevan Mission?

A government mission providing safe piped tap water to rural households across India.

10. What is the Fit India Movement?

A government initiative launched in 2019 to encourage regular physical activity across all age groups.

11. Are "sugar-free" or "fat-free" products automatically healthy?

Not necessarily — always check the full nutrition panel and ingredient list.

12. What percentage of India's disease burden is linked to diet?

An estimated 56.4%, according to ICMR-NIN's 2024 guidelines.

13. What are ultra-processed foods?

Industrially manufactured foods, often high in refined sugar, salt, and unhealthy fats, and low in fibre.

14. Does skipping meals help with weight loss?

Not reliably — it often leads to overeating later and can disrupt metabolism.

15. What is Poshan Abhiyaan?

India's National Nutrition Mission, focused on reducing malnutrition among children and women.

16. Who regulates food labelling in India?

The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI).

17. What allergens must be declared on Indian food labels?

The 8 major allergens, including gluten-containing cereals, must be clearly highlighted.

18. Is it necessary to join a gym to stay fit?

No — brisk walking, home workouts, and daily movement are genuinely effective.

19. What is front-of-pack nutrition labelling?

A simplified labelling system, directed by the Supreme Court in 2026, to help consumers quickly identify high fat, sugar, or salt content.

20. Why is fibre important in the diet?

It supports healthy digestion and helps maintain steady blood sugar levels.

21. What does "hidden hunger" mean?

Micronutrient deficiency that can exist even when overall calorie intake seems sufficient.

22. Should children have the same diet plate proportions as adults?

The same general principles apply, though specific nutrient needs vary by age — consult a paediatrician or dietitian for children's specific needs.

23. Can I trust the word "natural" on a food package?

Not on its own — always verify against the actual ingredients list and nutrition panel.

24. What's a simple first step toward a healthier daily routine?

Pick one habit — like a daily walk or checking one food label — and build consistency before adding more.

25. Where can I find India's official dietary guidelines?

Through ICMR-National Institute of Nutrition's published Dietary Guidelines for Indians.

Suggested Infographics, Flowcharts & Tables

Infographic: "My Plate for the Day" with labelled food group proportions.

Illustration: How to read a food label, step by step, with a sample label.

Chart: BMI categories with a simple visual scale.

Poster: A week of simple, balanced Indian meal ideas.

Card: Daily hydration guide by activity level and climate.

Official References

- ICMR-National Institute of Nutrition (NIN) — Dietary Guidelines for Indians, 2024, and "My Plate for the Day."
- ICMR-NIN — Nutrient Requirements for Indians: Recommended Dietary Allowances and Estimated Average Requirements, 2020.
- Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) — Eat Right India movement and labelling regulations.
- Food Safety and Standards (Labelling and Display) Regulations, 2020, Government of India.
- Jal Jeevan Mission, Ministry of Jal Shakti, Government of India.
- Ministry of Youth Affairs & Sports, Government of India — Fit India Movement.

Official Government Website Links

Resource	Website
ICMR-National Institute of Nutrition	nin.res.in
Eat Right India (FSSAI)	eatrightindia.gov.in
FSSAI	fssai.gov.in
Jal Jeevan Mission	jaljeevanmission.gov.in
Fit India Movement	fitindia.gov.in

Conclusion

Healthy living doesn't require perfection, expensive ingredients, or extreme routines — it requires consistency. A balanced plate, a habit of checking labels, steady hydration, regular movement, and safe drinking water together form a foundation that quietly protects your health for decades.

As you move ahead in the JanGyan platform, use the Practice and Quiz sections to reinforce what you've learned here, and don't hesitate to use AI Assistance whenever a doubt arises. Small, sustainable choices, repeated daily, are what truly build lifelong health.

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